

SOURDOUGH

The Jessica Smithson Method

An Instructional Guide



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work of:

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To be referenced for the cre-
ation, care, and consumption
of sourdough bread.

materials

SUPPLIES NEEDED

- Kitchen Scale
- Dutch Oven
- Proofing Bowl
- Cheesecloth Towel
- Large Mason Jars
- Razor
- Rubber Band
- Measuring Cups
- Large Mixing Bowls
- Clear, Marked Container
- Bench Scraper
- Parchment Paper

FEEDING

Feed your starter on a weekly basis. You can use your starter for baking on the day you feed it, or return it to the fridge after feeding to sustain it.

- Large mason jar or a sealable glass container
- Kitchen Scale
- 100 grams warm water
- 100 grams all-purpose flour
- Current starter
- Rubber band or tape for marking the level of the starter

BAKING

The most important material you need for baking sourdough is time. The process requires around 10 hours, with another 24-48 after for proofing.

The materials you will need for baking a loaf of sourdough are:

- Activated starter that has doubled in size since feeding
- ~360 grams warm filtered water
- 11 grams salt
- 500 grams all-purpose flour
- Food scale
- Measuring cups (larger size)
- Bowl for mixing dough
- Clear container with marked measurements for bulk fermentation
- Bench scraper / spatula
- Proofing bowl + towel
- Razor
- Parchment Paper
- Dutch Oven

feeding

IF YOUR STARTER ISN'T RISING IN THE FRIDGE

A starter failing to rise in the fridge isn't a sure sign of anything, but try these approaches to keep it activated:

Leave the starter out on the counter for up to 8 hours, it might rise on its own.

Feed the starter like normal, then leave it on the counter until the next day, then feed it again like normal.

SUPPLIES NEEDED

Sourdough starter should be fed weekly, or at the very least bi-weekly. Keep your starter re-fridgerated when not in use.

To feed your starter, you need:

- Large mason jar
- kitchen scale
- 100 grams warm filtered water
- 100 grams flour

HOW TO FEED YOUR SOURDOUGH STARTER

1. Discard all but 50 grams of your sourdough starter. If you have the weight of your original container, you can measure in that container. Otherwise, use a new jar on the kitchen scale.
2. Mix 100 grams of warm filtered water in with your 50 grams of starter. The starter will start to dissolve into the water as you stir.
3. Mix in the 100 grams of flour. Some bakers avoid using metal utensils for stirring, but we have not noticed a difference.

IF YOU ARE PREPARING A LOAF TODAY

Place the jar of mixed starter on the counter. Mark the height of the starter in the jar with a rubber band or piece of tape. Leave the starter on the counter until the height has more than doubled, then use for the baking process.

IF YOU ARE NOT PREPARING A LOAF TODAY

Leave the jar of mixed starter on the counter for ten minutes. After ten minutes, place a lid on the jar and re-fridgerate until needed.

preparing

Turning your activated starter into usable dough takes around 10 hours. After that, it will take another 24-48 hours to fully proof.

Before starting the baking process, ensure that your starter is activated. A sourdough starter is considered activated if it has more than doubled in size since its last feeding.

SUPPLIES NEEDED

- Activated starter that has doubled in size since feeding
- 355 grams warm filtered water
- 11 grams salt
- 500 grams all-purpose flour
- Brown rice flour
- Food scale
- Measuring cups (larger size)
- Bowl for mixing dough
- Clear container with marked measurements for bulk fermentation
- Bench scraper / spatula
- Proofing bowl + towel
- Razor
- Parchment paper
- Dutch oven

MIXING THE DOUGH

Prepare a large bowl for mixing and a large clear container for bulk fermentation.

In the bowl:

1. Mix 50-100 grams of activated starter with 355 grams of warm distilled water.
2. Thoroughly mix the water and starter. It is okay if the starter dissolves into the water.
3. Add 11 grams of salt and stir.
4. Slowly add in 500 grams of flour while mixing. Mix only until combined.
5. Transfer to the large clear container so you can clearly see when the dough rises.
6. Let rest for 30 minutes, then stretch and fold the dough ten times.
7. Repeat the stretching and folding process three more times, or four times in total. If you are adding ingredients to your bread, do so during the third folding.

BULK FERMENTATION

Once you have finished the stretching and folding process, use a thin towel to cover the container. Use a rubber band or a piece of tape to indicate the starting point of your dough.

Leave the dough out in this container for bulk fermentation. Check in on your dough periodically until it has grown in size by 50%. This process usually takes around 6 hours.

SHAPING

Before you can finally rest and proof the dough, it needs to be shaped. To shape the dough:

1. Place the dough on a floured surface.
2. Fold the dough in half from the bottom, then rotate the dough and repeat 2 times.
3. Let dough rest for 30 minutes.

PROOFING

Prepare a proofing bowl by lining with a light towel (unless included) and sprinkling brown rice flour into the bottom. Then,

1. Transfer the dough into the prepared proofing bowl.
2. Cover the bowl lightly with plastic wrap to prevent dehydration.
3. Place the bowl in the fridge for at least 24 hours. At most 48 hours.

baking and trouble- shooting

BAKING

Once the proofing process has been completed:

1. Place your dutch oven in the oven and preheat to 550. Let preheat for at least half an hour.
2. Place your dough onto a floured surface and score the top.
3. Cut a piece of parchment paper large enough to line the dutch oven and place the loaf on it.
4. Place your loaf into the dutch oven and cover.
5. Lower the oven temperature to 450 and bake for 30 minutes.
6. Lower the oven temperature to 400, remove the dutch oven lid, and bake for 10-15 minutes.

NOTES ON BAKING

During the final step of baking, check for crispiness periodically.

Let bread cool for at least one hour to allow the baking process to complete.

If the loaf is sticking to the parchment paper, try dusting with brown rice flour before baking.

To avoid contact with the preheated dutch oven, consider inverting the dough into the oven over parchment paper to place it in, then scoring after.

FREQUENT ISSUES AND THEIR CAUSES

Bread has too many holes:
Dough is under-fermented

Bread is too thick:
Dough is under-fermented

Bread is too flat:
Dough is over-fermented

Dough has collapsed bubbles, or is losing structure:
dough is moderately over-fermented

Starter is slimy / watery:
starter needs a higher ratio of flour to water, and a longer fermentation time.

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS

How accurate do my measurements need to be?

The water to flour ratio is an incredibly important part of the sourdough process. The measurements for flour and water should be precise. Measuring out your starter requires less precision, as the starter only needs to be introduced to begin fermentation.

Why is my dough flattening?
Your dough will likely flatten during periods of rest. So long as you can reshape the dough after the rest, there is no need for concern.